

The Signaling Gap:

State-Owned Media and the Strategic Management of Sentiment during the Russian Invasion of Ukraine

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Abstract

Alliance commitments are designed to facilitate cooperation, but they can also prevent states from expressing disagreement through formal diplomatic channels, even when they genuinely dissent. We argue that state-owned media provides a mechanism for constrained states to signal genuine preferences to foreign governments, occupying a middle ground between formal channels that are too visible and private diplomacy that lacks credibility. Analyzing state media coverage before and after the 2022 invasion of Ukraine, we find that the invasion produced a larger negative shift in sentiment toward Russia in states with Russian security agreements than in neutral states. This occurred despite these same states refusing to formally condemn the invasion. Our analysis bridges a gap between international relations scholarship, which has largely treated state media as a domestic tool, and Western intelligence services, which have monitored it as a window into regime preferences since the Cold War.

Introduction

States that depend on a powerful patron for their security do not always have the luxury of saying what they think. Formal diplomatic channels—UN votes, official statements, public breaks—become liabilities when using them risks retaliation from

the very power that guarantees a state’s survival. Yet when a patron’s actions draw international condemnation, silence risks being seen as endorsement. The Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022—the largest land war in Europe since World War II—confronted Russia’s formal security partners with exactly this bind. States bound to Russia through the Collective Security Treaty Organization and other formal security agreements had genuine reasons to oppose the invasion. It violated the sovereignty norms that protect small states and threatened their substantial economic ties with the West. But open condemnation of a security patron that had already demonstrated its willingness to use force in its near abroad was not a viable option. This is not a new problem. During the Cold War, Soviet-aligned states used state-owned media to communicate positions that formal diplomatic channels could not carry—and Western intelligence analysts learned to read those signals as indicators of genuine preferences (Cohen, 1987). We argue that the same channel Soviet-aligned states once used to signal under constraint remains operative today, and that the 2022 invasion reveals its logic with unusual clarity.

International relations scholarship has predominantly studied state media as a tool of domestic audience management (McCombs, 2002; Guriev & Treisman, 2022). Western governments, however, have monitored state media as a source of international intelligence for decades (Favere, 2024; Monitoring, 2016), treating deviations from official positions as signals of genuine regime preferences (Williams & Blum, 2018). We build on this practitioner insight to argue that state-owned media functions as an informal signaling channel through which constrained states communicate genuine preferences to external audiences—particularly Western governments. The credibility of this channel derives from the nature of state-owned media itself. External observers understand these outlets to be under government control, which means that when Kazakh or Belarusian state media shifts against Russia, foreign analysts do not interpret this as independent journalism but as a regime choice. This monitoring has only intensified in recent decades as open-source intelligence has become formalized within diplomatic and intelligence institutions (Manor, 2019;USIC, 2024). States in our sample are

aware of this scrutiny, giving senders reason to believe their signals will be received and correctly interpreted. Furthermore, the signal is costly because allowing negative coverage of a security patron risks provoking retaliation from Moscow, a real cost that makes bluffing irrational. Crucially, state-owned media also offers what formal diplomatic channels cannot: deniability. The institutional separation between the government and state-owned media outlets gives states a tool to manage the relationship with Moscow if confronted.

Why state media rather than other channels? States facing this dilemma have a range of tools available, and the choice between them is not whether to signal, but a strategic calculus that must balance visibility and risk. The most public instruments—UN votes, formal diplomatic statements—are highly visible and directly attributable, which is precisely what makes them too costly for states bound by security agreements. The least visible alternative—quiet, private diplomatic meetings—avoids provocation but sacrifices credibility; a message delivered behind closed doors is unverifiable by the audiences it is meant to reach and easily dismissed as cheap talk (Fearon, 1997). State-owned media occupies the middle ground. It is public enough to be observed by foreign governments that systematically monitor it, yet it preserves enough institutional distance from official policy that the sending state retains plausible deniability.

We test this argument by exploiting variation in formal security relationships with Russia across twelve states in Russia’s near abroad, drawing on a corpus of several hundred thousand newspaper articles published before and after the invasion.¹ Four states were bound to Russia through the Collective Security Treaty Organization or equivalent bilateral security agreements at the time of the invasion. Four occupied broadly neutral positions, maintaining distance from both Russian security structures and full Western integration. The remaining states are NATO members. We employ a generative AI model (GPT-4o) to measure sentiment toward Russia at the article

¹The twelve states span three categories of alignment. Russia-aligned: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, and Kazakhstan. Neutral: Georgia, Moldova, Kosovo, and Serbia. NATO-aligned: Albania, Hungary, and Turkey. Ukraine is included in the dataset but excluded from the main analysis given its direct role as the invaded party.

level, validating performance against a human-coded gold standard. Our identification strategy uses the sharp discontinuity of February 24 to estimate the causal effect of the invasion on media sentiment within each group through a regression discontinuity in time design. To compare across groups, we leverage a Regression Difference-in-Discontinuity Design (RDID). The sharp discontinuity of the invasion substantially reduces confounding concerns, though comparisons across groups remain correlational in nature. We subject these comparisons to extensive robustness checks, which we detail in our methods section.

Our findings build sequentially. We first establish that the invasion produced a genuine negative shock to media sentiment toward Russia across the region—without this baseline, the divergence we identify in subsequent tests would be uninterpretable. We then show that this decline was not uniform: independent media responded significantly more negatively than state-owned media, consistent with strategic management of coverage by state outlets. The critical test of our argument comes in the comparison across security relationships. A straightforward domestic audience management account would predict that Russia-aligned states suppress negative coverage to protect the alliance relationship. Instead, we find the opposite: state-owned media in states with Russian security agreements shifted more negatively toward Russia than state-owned media in neutral states, despite these same states refusing to condemn the invasion through formal diplomatic channels. This pattern is consistent with constrained states using media to signal genuine dissatisfaction to external audiences precisely because formal channels were unavailable.

This paper makes two primary contributions. First, our analysis demonstrates that the signals practitioners have long monitored are theoretically structured and empirically identifiable. The patterns we document are not idiosyncratic to a single crisis but follow directly from the logic of alliance constraints: states whose formal channels are constrained by dependence on a powerful patron produce systematically different media signals than states whose channels remain open. This suggests that state media sentiment is not merely noise but a legible instrument of international communication,

one that the discipline can study with the same rigor it applies to formal diplomatic behavior. Second, we identify an understudied mechanism of informal signaling under alliance constraints. The signaling literature has focused on how states communicate resolve to adversaries or commitment to allies through formal channels; we demonstrate that when those channels are foreclosed, states turn to informal ones, and that the resulting signals follow predictable patterns rooted in the structure of their security commitments. Methodologically, our approach pairs generative AI-based sentiment measurement with a regression discontinuity design, offering a template for large-scale analysis of media signals in contexts where hand-coding is infeasible.

The article proceeds as follows. We first develop our theoretical argument and derive three hypotheses about media divergence under alliance constraints. We then present the case, justifying our sample and identification strategy. The following sections describe our data and research design before presenting results. We conclude by discussing implications for how states signal preferences under geopolitical constraint.

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